

EYEWITNESS 1970s

Boat People

After the unification of Vietnam, many South Vietnamese people fled by boat to avoid persecution under the new regime. Vuong Thanh Loc's middle-class family owned a grocery store, and two of his brothers had worked for the South Vietnamese government. Vuong had tried to escape seven times and had been jailed twice, before he embarked on the difficult journey that would eventually take him to Australia.

The boat was very small, around 26 ft (8 m) long and 10 ft (3 m) wide, but fifty people were crammed into it like sardines in a can. It was unseaworthy; the engine was very old and it did not have a hooded cover, exposing it to the elements. The owner had promised a bigger ship would be waiting for them out at sea, but he had tricked them. In the hope a ship at sea could save them, they carried on with their journey. The weather was good and they prayed to keep their hopes up.

But the engine broke down after ten hours at sea, and with no sails or paddles, the boat was left adrift. Food was scarce and ran out two days later. On the third day, some ships appeared but did not stop to help. Finally, on the night of seventh day the boat came ashore but they did not know where they were until the police came. They had arrived in Malaysia.

“ We realized now how important escaping was, it was too late for us to return.”

VUONG THANH LOC, FROM *VIETKA*, ARCHIVES OF VIETNAMESE BOAT PEOPLE, 2005